Home blood pressure: the method matters too

> *An unexpected number can be worrying. Comparable readings are more useful than hurried repeated checks.*

Choose the right equipment

Use a validated upper-arm monitor with a cuff that fits. Bring it to a consultation to check technique. Do not diagnose or change treatment from one reading.

Prepare and position

Avoid smoking, caffeine and exercise for 30 minutes beforehand, empty your bladder and rest quietly for five minutes. Sit with back supported, feet flat and legs uncrossed. Support a bare arm at heart level and do not talk.

Keep both readings

Take two readings about a minute apart at the times agreed with your clinician. Record both, with date, time and symptoms. Do not keep only the lower result or compare your target with another patient’s.

Very high readings

If systolic pressure is above 180 or diastolic above 120 with chest pain, breathlessness, weakness, vision or speech changes, seek emergency help without delaying for repeat readings. Without symptoms, wait at least a minute and repeat; if still this high, contact a clinician urgently. Do not add a dose on your own.

For a life-threatening emergency in India, call 112. Elsewhere use your local emergency number.

Symptoms can outweigh the number

Severe chest pain, stroke symptoms or major breathing difficulty needs emergency assessment even when the monitor is not showing a very high value. Continue prescribed treatment unless your team advises otherwise.

Questions you may have

Can I stop treatment when home readings look good?

No. Treatment may be the reason they are controlled. Discuss changes with your clinician.

What to remember

Correct technique, an honest record and attention to symptoms make home monitoring useful.

Sources and further reading

American Heart Association — home blood-pressure monitoring
https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure/understanding-blood-pressure-readings/monitoring-your-blood-pressure-at-home

American Heart Association — severe blood pressure and warning symptoms
https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure/changes-you-can-make-to-manage-high-blood-pressure

Government of India — Emergency Response Support System 112
https://112.gov.in/about

Educational information supports understanding and does not replace individual medical care. Follow your clinician’s plan. Do not change medicines on your own. Sources checked: 24 October 2026.

Website: https://home-visiting-icu-doctor.vercel.app/#wikiSection
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